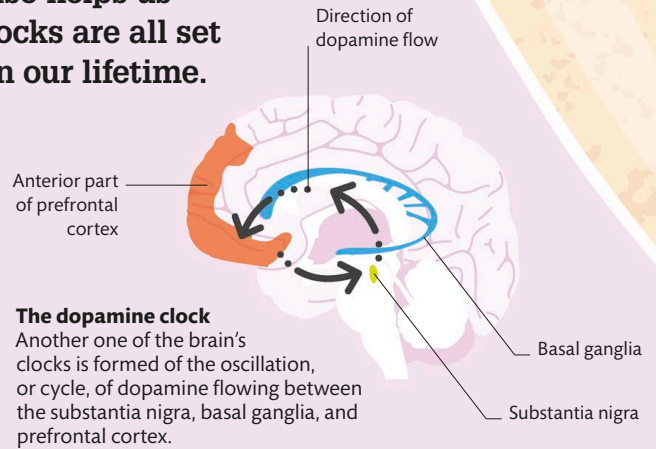


Time

We can measure time objectively—by hours, minutes, and seconds—with clocks, but our brain also helps us keep track of time passing. Our internal clocks are all set at different speeds and even change within our lifetime.

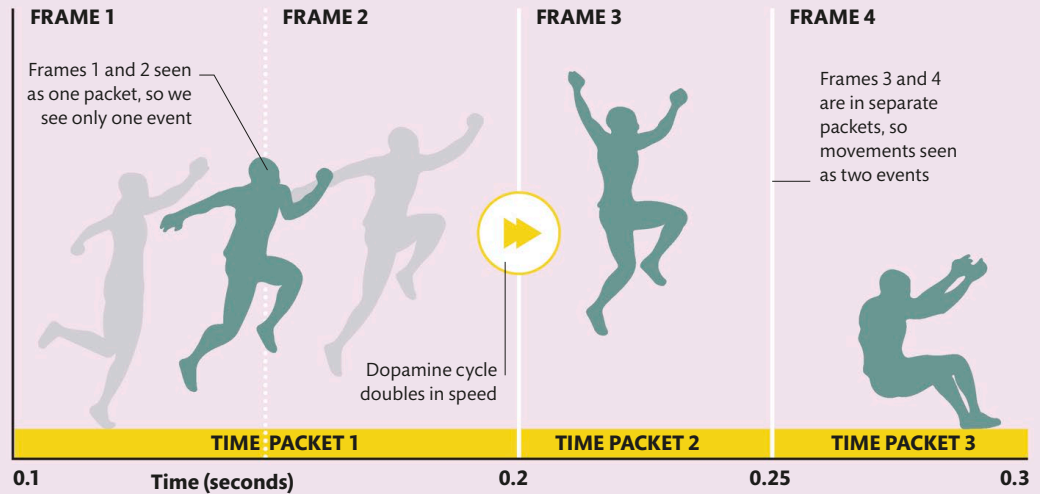
The timekeeper brain

Our concept of time is linked to a neural network involved in memory and attention. Neurons in the network fire, or “oscillate,” and the brain uses this to keep time. The more oscillations in a measured second, the more we think that time is lasting longer. Events (such as near-death experiences), state of mind (such as depression), stimulants (such as caffeine), and disease (such as Parkinson's disease) can all affect the rate at which the neurons fire, skewing our perception of time.



Packets of time

One cycle of a brain clock equals one “packet” of time, which we register as a single event. Just as a camera with a higher frame rate will capture more details in a sequence of events, faster rates of neuronal firing will create more time packets, registering more events.



TIME ILLUSIONS

Distance can skew our perception of time. If three lights flash one after another at equal time intervals (of 10 seconds, for example) but the distance between lights “B” and “C” is greater than the distance between “A” and “B,” it will create the illusion that the time between “B” and “C” flashing was longer than 10 seconds.

